INDIA TODAY CONCLAVE 2022 EAST

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GRAPPLING WITH THE STATE OF INDIAN POLITICS, GOVERNANCE WALKS OF LIFE MADE THE INDIA TODAY CONCLAVE EAST 2022 A

By Romita Dutta



Photographs by CHANDRADEEP KUMAR AND DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

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At a time when the nation's atmosphere is volatile and politically charged, and rancour and hatred are thick in the air, the fifth edition of India Today Group's Conclave East deliberated, debated and opened up dialogue on some of the most polarising issues of our time. The intellectual churn of the event, over two consecutive days, spread clarity, buried misunderstandings, brought people closer and inevitably sparked fresh controversy.

West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee, as a bulwark of the Opposition, not only gave glimpses of what a future, alternative leader would be like, she yet again warned that any Maharashtra-like experiment in Bengal would be the BJP's biggest blunder. The 2021 assembly elections loss still possibly stings, but Amit Shah is undeterred. In her solo session—"National Affairs: The Vision for an Alternative Leadership", Mamata has accepted Shah's challenge, reminding him how well fortified Bengal is: "First learn to swim, then dare to cross Bay of Bengal. Then there's the Royal Bengal tiger. My people are my Royal Bengal tigers."

Trinamool MP Saugata Ray and social welfare minister Shashi Panja in their respective sessions held Bengal as an example of resistance to the flood of